
The Changing Contours of Political Community: Rethinking Democracy in the Context of Globalisation

Author(s): David Held

Source: *Theoria: A Journal of Social and Political Theory*, December 1999, No. 94, Governance and Globalisation (December 1999), pp. 30-47

Published by: Berghahn Books

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/41802122>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



JSTOR

is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Theoria: A Journal of Social and Political Theory*

The Changing Contours of Political Community

Rethinking Democracy in the Context of Globalisation

David Held

Political communities are in the process of being transformed. Of course, transformation can take many forms. But one type of transformation is of particular concern in this paper: the progressive enmeshment of human communities with each other. Over the last few centuries, human communities have come into increasing contact with each other; their collective fortunes have become intertwined. I want to dwell on this and its implications.

The focus will be on the changing nature of political community in the context of the growing interconnectedness of states and societies – in short, globalisation. The paper¹ has a number of parts. In the first part, I explore some of the key assumptions and presuppositions of liberal democracy; above all, its conception of political community. In the second part, I explore changing forms of globalisation. In my view, globalisation has been with us for some time, but its extensity, intensity and impact have changed fundamentally. In the third and final part, the implications of changing forms of globalisation are explored in relation to the prospects of democratic political community.

Part I: The Presuppositions of Liberal Democracy

Until the eighteenth century, democracy was generally associated with the gathering of citizens in assemblies and public meeting places. From the late eighteenth century, it began to be thought of as the right of citizens to participate in the determination of the collective will, but now through the medium of elected representatives (Bobbio 1989). The theory of liberal or representative democracy fundamentally shifted the terms of reference of democratic thought: the practical limits that a sizeable citizenry imposes on democracy – which had been the focus of so much critical (anti-democratic) atten-

Theoria, December 1999

tion – were thought to be eradicable. Representative democracy could now be celebrated as both accountable and feasible government, potentially stable over great territories and time spans (see Dahl 1989: 28-30). As one of the best known advocates of the representative system put it, ‘by ingrafting representation upon democracy’ a system of government is created that is capable of embracing ‘all the various interests and every extent of territory and population’ (Paine 1987: 281). Representative democracy could even be heralded, as James Mill wrote, ‘as the grand discovery of modern times’ in which ‘the solution of all difficulties, both speculative and practical, would be found’ (quoted in Sabine 1963: 695). Accordingly, the theory and practice of democratic government broke away from its traditional association with small states and cities, opening itself to become the legitimating creed of the emerging world of modern nation-states.

Built, as it was, against the background of the formation of the modern nation-state, the development of liberal democracy took place within a particular conceptual space (cf. Walker 1988; Connolly 1991; McGrew 1997). Modern democratic theory and practice was constructed upon national, territorial foundations. National communities, and theories of national communities, were based on the presupposition that political communities could, in principle, control their destinies and citizens could come to identify sufficiently with each other such that they might think and act together with a view of what was best for all of them, that is, with a view of the common good (Sandel 1996: 202). It was taken for granted that, bar internal difficulties, the demos, the extent of the franchise, the form and scope of representation and the nature and meaning of consent – in fact all the key elements of self-determination – could be specified with respect to geography: systems of representation and democratic accountability could be neatly meshed with the spatial reach of sites of power in a circumscribed territory. Moreover, as a consequence of this, clear-cut distinctions could be elaborated, and national institutions built upon the difference between ‘internal’ and ‘external’ policy, between domestic and foreign affairs.

Of course, the construction of a national democratic community was often deeply contested as different social, economic and cultural groups fought with each other about the nature of this community and about their own status within it. Nonetheless, the theory of democracy, particularly as it developed in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, could take for granted the link between the demos, citizenship, electoral mechanisms, the nature of consent, and the boundaries of

the nation-state. The fates of different political communities may be intertwined, but the appropriate place for determining the foundation of 'national fate' is the national community itself. Accordingly, modern democratic theory and democratic politics assumes a symmetry and congruence between citizen-voters and national decision-makers. Through the ballot box, citizen-voters are, in principle, able to hold decision-makers to account; and, as a result of electoral consent, decision-makers are able to make and pursue law and policy legitimately for their constituents, ultimately, the people in a fixed, territorially based community.

Part II: Changing Forms of Regional and Global Order

At the centre of the dominant theoretical approaches to democratic politics is an uncritically appropriated concept of the territorial political community. And the difficulty with this is that political communities have rarely – if ever – existed in isolation as bounded geographical totalities; they are better thought of as overlapping networks of interaction. These networks crystallise around different sites and forms of power – economic, political, military, cultural, among others – producing diverse patterns of activity which do not correspond in any simple and straightforward way to territorial boundaries (see Mann 1986: chapter 1). Modern political communities are, and have always been, locked into a diversity of processes and structures which range in and through them. The theory and practice of the democratic sovereign state has always been in some tension with the actuality of state sovereignty and autonomy. How, then, should one understand these patterns of interconnections, and their changing form over time? And how should one understand their political implications, in particular, for sovereignty, autonomy and the democratic political community?

The term 'globalisation' captures some of the changes which shape the nature of the political and the prospects of political community; unpacking this term helps create a framework for addressing some of the issues to be explored. Globalisation can be understood in relation to a set of processes which shift the spatial form of human organisation and activity to transcontinental or inter-regional patterns of activity, interaction and the exercise of power (see Goldblatt, Held, McGrew & Perraton 1998).² It involves a stretching and deepening of social relations and institutions across space and time such that, on

the one hand, day-to-day activities are increasingly influenced by events happening on the other side of the globe and, on the other, the practices and decisions of local groups or communities can have significant global reverberations (see Giddens 1990). It is possible to distinguish different historical forms of globalisation in terms of (1) the extensiveness of networks of relations and connections; (2) the intensity of flows and levels of activity within these networks; and (3) the impact of these phenomena on particular bounded communities. It is not a case of saying, as many do, that there was no globalisation, there is now; rather, it is a case of recognising that forms of globalisation have changed over time and that these can be systematically understood by reference to points (1) to (3) above. Such an historical approach to globalisation contrasts with the current fashion to suggest either that globalisation is fundamentally new – the ‘hyper-globalisation school’, with its insistence that global markets are now fully established (see Ohmae 1990) – or that there is nothing unprecedented about contemporary levels of international economic and social interaction since they resemble those of the gold standard era, the ‘skeptical school’ (see Hirst & Thompson 1996).

Globalisation is neither a singular condition nor a linear process. Rather, it is best thought of as a multi-dimensional phenomenon involving domains of activity and interaction that include the economic, political, technological, military, legal, cultural and environmental. Each of these spheres involves different patterns of relations and activities. A general account of globalisation cannot simply predict from one domain what will occur in another. It is necessary to keep these distinctive domains separate and to build a theory of globalisation and its impact on particular political communities from an understanding of what is happening in each and every one of them.

At least two tasks are necessary in order to pursue this objective, although, of course, not to complete it. First, it is important to illustrate some of the fundamental alterations in the patterns of interconnectedness among political communities. Secondly, it is important to set out some of the political implications of these changes. In what follows, I start by illustrating some of the transformations which have brought a change in the organisation and meaning of political community.

(1) Among the significant developments which are changing the nature of political community are global economic processes, especially growth in trade, production and financial transactions, organised in part by rapidly expanding multinational companies. Trade has

grown substantially, reaching unprecedented levels, particularly in the post Second World War period. Not only has there been an increase in intra-regional trade around the world, but there has also been sustained growth among regions as well (see Perraton, Goldblatt, Held & McGrew 1997). More countries are involved in global trading arrangements, for instance, India and China, and more people and nations are affected by such arrangements. If there is a further lowering of tariff barriers across the world, along with a further reduction of transportation and communication costs, these trends are likely to continue and to further the extension, intensity and impact of trade relations on other domains of life. The expansion of global financial flows has, moreover, been particularly rapid in the last 10-15 years. Foreign exchange turnover has mushroomed and is now around 1.2 trillion dollars a day. Much of this financial activity is speculative and generates fluctuations in prices (of stocks, shares, futures, etc.) in excess of those which can be accounted for by changes in the fundamentals of asset values. The enormous growth of global financial flows across borders, linked to the liberalisation of capital markets from the late 1970s, has created a more integrated financial system than has ever been known.

Underpinning this economic shift has been the growth of multinational corporations, both productive and financial. Approximately 20 000 multinational corporations now account for a quarter to a third of world output, 70 percent of world trade and 80 percent of foreign direct investment. They are essential to the diffusion of skills and technology, and they are key players in the international money markets. In addition, multinational corporations can have profound effects on macroeconomic policy. They can respond to variations in interest rates by raising finance in whichever capital market is most favourable. They can shift their demand for employment to countries with much lower employment costs. And in the area of industrial policy, especially technology policy, they can move activities to where the maximum benefits accrue.

It is easy to misrepresent the political significance of the globalisation of economic activity. There are those, earlier referred to as the 'hyper-globalisers', who argue that we now live in a world in which social and economic processes operate predominantly at a global level (see Ohmae 1990; Reich 1991). According to these thinkers, national political communities are now immersed in a sea of global economic flows and are inevitably 'decision takers' in this context. For many neo-liberal thinkers, this is a welcome development; a

world market order based on the principles of free trade and minimum regulation is the guarantee of liberty, efficiency and effective government (see Hayek 1960: 405-6). By contrast, however, there are those who are more reserved about the extent and benefits of the globalisation of economic activity. They point out, for instance, that for all the expansion in global flows of trade and investment, the majority of economic activity still occurs on a more restricted spatial scale – in national economies and in the OECD countries. They also point out that the historical evidence suggests that contemporary forms of international economic interaction are not without precedent – and they refer to the gold standard era for some substantial and interesting comparisons (see Hirst & Thompson 1996; cf. Perraton, Goldblatt, Held & McGrew 1997).

But the claims of the hyper-globalisers and their critics misstate much of what is significant about contemporary economic globalisation for politics. Nation-states continue to be immensely powerful, and enjoy access to a formidable range of resources, bureaucratic infrastructural capacity and technologies of co-ordination and control. The continuing lobbying of states by MNCs confirms the enduring importance of states to the mediation and regulation of economic activity. Yet it is wrong to argue that globalisation is a mere illusion, an ideological veil, that allows politicians simply to disguise the causes of poor performance and policy failure. Although the rhetoric of hyper-globalisation has provided many an elected politician with a conceptual resource for refusing political responsibility, globalisation has significant and discernible characteristics which alter the balance of resources, economic and political, within and across borders.

Among the most important of these characteristics is the tangible growth in the enmeshment of national economies in global economic transactions (i.e. a growing proportion of nearly all national economies involves international economic exchanges with an increasing number of countries). This increase in the extent and intensity of economic interconnectedness has altered the relation between economic and political power. One shift has been particularly significant:

the historic expansion of exit options for capital in financial markets relative to national capital controls, national banking regulations and national investment strategies, and the sheer volume of privately held capital relative to national reserves. Exit options for corporations making direct investments have also expanded ... the balance of power has shifted in favour of capital *vis-à-vis* both national governments and national labour movements. (Goldblatt, Held, McGrew & Perraton 1997)

As a result, the autonomy of democratically elected governments has been, and is increasingly, constrained by sources of unelected and unrepresentative economic power. These have the effect of making adjustment to the international economy (and, above all, to global financial markets) a fixed point of orientation in economic policy and of encouraging an acceptance of the 'decision signals' of its leading agents and forces as a, if not the, standard of rational decision-making. The options for political communities, and the costs and benefits of them, ineluctably alter.

(2) Within the realms of the media and culture there are also grounds for thinking that there is a growing disjuncture between the idea of the democratic state as an independent, accountable centre of power bounded by fixed borders – in this case, a centre of national culture, able to foster and sustain a national identity – and interlinked changes in the spheres of media and cultural exchange. A number of developments in recent times can be highlighted. English has spread as the dominant language of élite cultures throughout the world: it is now the dominant language in business, computing, law, science and politics. The internationalisation and globalisation of telecommunications have been extraordinarily rapid: international telephone traffic increased more than fourfold between 1983 and 1995; there has been a massive increase in transnational cable links; there has been an explosion in satellite links; and the Internet has provided a remarkable increase in the infrastructure of horizontal and lateral communication capacity within and across borders. Moreover, substantial multimedia conglomerates have developed, such as the Murdoch Empire and Time Warner. In addition, there has been a huge increase in tourism. For example, in 1960 there were 70 million international tourists, while in 1994 there were nearly 500 million. And in television and film there are similar trends.

None of the above examples, or the accumulative impact of parallel cases, should be taken to imply the development of a single global, media-led culture (consider the impact of Star television in India). But certainly, taken together, these developments do imply that many new forms of communication media range in and across borders, linking nations and peoples in new ways. The creation and recreation of new forms of identity – often linked to patterns of consumption and the entertainment industries – are not to be underestimated. In this context, the capacity of national political leaders to sustain a national culture has become more complex and difficult. Even in China, for example, where the authorities sought to restrict access to and use of

western media, films and the Internet, it has found this extremely difficult to do, especially with regard to young people. All independent states may retain a legal claim to 'effective supremacy over what occurs within their territories', but this is significantly compromised by the growing enmeshment of 'the national' with transnational influences (see Keohane 1995). The determination of political community and the nature of political identity within it become less a territorial matter and more a matter of transaction, exchange and bargaining across a complex set of transnational networks. At the very least, national political communities by no means simply determine the structure, education and cultural flows in and through which citizens are cultivated. Citizens' values and judgements are now formed in a complex web of national, international and global cultural exchange.

(3) Environmental problems and challenges are perhaps the clearest and starkest examples of the global shift in human organisation and activity, creating some of the most fundamental pressures on the efficacy of the nation-state and state-centric democratic politics. There are three types of problems at issue:

- a) the first is shared problems involving the global commons, i.e. fundamental elements of the ecosystem, and among the most significant challenges here are global warming and ozone depletion.
- b) a second category of global environmental problems involves the interlinked challenges of demographic expansion and resource consumption. Pressing examples under this heading include desertification, questions of bio-diversity and threats to the existence of certain species.
- c) a third category of problems is transboundary pollution such as acid rain, or river pollutants, or the contaminated rain which fell in connection with Chernobyl.

In response to the progressive development of, and publicity surrounding, environmental problems in the last two decades, there has been an interlinked process of cultural and political globalisation as illustrated by the emergence of new cultural, scientific and intellectual networks; new environmental movements with transnational organisations and transnational concerns; and new institutions and conventions like those agreed in 1992 at the Earth Summit in Brazil. Not all environmental problems are, of course, global; such an implication would be entirely false. But there has been a striking shift in the phys-

ical and environmental conditions – that is, in the extent and intensity of environmental problems – affecting human affairs in general. These processes have moved politics dramatically away from an activity which crystallises first and foremost around state and interstate concerns. It is clearer than ever that the fortunes of political communities and peoples can no longer be simply understood in exclusively national or territorial terms. As one commentator aptly noted,

in the context of intense global and regional interconnectedness, the very idea of political community as an exclusive territorially delimited unit is at best unconvincing and at worst anachronistic. In a world in which global warming connects the long-term fate of many Pacific islands to the actions of tens of millions of private motorists across the globe, the conventional territorial conception of political community appears profoundly inadequate. Globalisation weaves together, in highly complex and abstract systems, the fate of households, communities and peoples in distant regions of the globe. (McGrew 1997: 237)

Political communities are locked into a diversity of processes and structures which range across them. It can be no surprise then that national communities do not make decisions and policies exclusively for themselves, and that governments today do not simply determine what is right or appropriate for their own citizens alone. While it would be a mistake to conclude that political communities are without distinctive degrees of division or cleavage at their borders, they are clearly shaped by multiple cross-border interaction networks and power systems. Thus, questions are raised both about the fate of the idea of political community and about the appropriate locus for the articulation of the democratic political good. The proper 'home' of politics and democracy becomes a quite puzzling matter.

(4) Changes in the development of international law have placed individuals, governments and non-governmental organisations under new systems of legal regulation. International law recognises powers and constraints, and rights and duties, which have qualified the principle of state sovereignty in a number of important respects; sovereignty per se is no longer a straightforward guarantee of international legitimacy. Entrenched in certain legal instruments is the view that a legitimate state must be a democratic state that upholds certain common values (see Crawford 1994). One significant area in this regard is human rights law and human rights regimes.

Of all the international declarations of rights, the European Convention for the Protection of Human Rights and Fundamental Free-

doms (1950) is particularly noteworthy. In marked contrast to the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the subsequent UN Covenants of Rights, the European Convention was concerned, as its preamble indicates, 'to take the first steps for the collective enforcement of certain of the rights stated in the Universal Declaration'. The European initiative was and remains a most radical legal innovation: an innovation which, against the stream of state history, allows individual citizens to initiate proceedings against their own governments. Within this framework, states are no longer free to treat their own citizens as they think fit (see Capotorti 1983: 977). Human rights regimes have also been promoted in other regions of the world, partly in response to United Nations encouragement that such rights should be entrenched at regional levels (see Evans 1997).

Each of the main UN human rights covenants has now been ratified by over 140 out of 190 states, and more are expected to ratify them. Increasing numbers of states appear willing to accept, in principle, general duties of protection and provision, as well as of restraint, in their own procedures and practices (see Beetham 1998). Clearly these commitments are rarely backed by coercive powers of enforcement. However, the demands of the new international human rights regimes – formal and informal – have created a plethora of transnational groups, movements, agencies and lawyers all engaged in reworking the nature of national politics, national sovereignty, and state accountability.

In international law, accordingly, there has been a gradual shift away from the principle that state sovereignty must be safeguarded irrespective of its consequences for individuals, groups and organisations. Respect for the autonomy of the subject, and for an extensive range of human rights, creates a new set of ordering principles in political affairs which can delimit and curtail the principle of effective state power. Along with other international legal changes (see Cassese 1986; Held 1995: chapter 5), these developments are indicative of an alteration in the weight granted, on the one hand, to claims made on behalf of the state system and, on the other hand, to those made on behalf of an alternative organising principle of world order, in which an unqualified state sovereignty no longer reigns supreme.

(5) While all the developments described so far have helped engender a shift away from a purely state-centred international system of 'high politics' to new and novel forms of geo-governance, a further interesting example of this process can be drawn from the very heart of the idea of a sovereign state – national security and

defence policy. There has been a notable increase in emphasis upon collective defence and co-operative security. The enormous costs, technological requirements and domestic burdens of defence are contributing to the strengthening of multilateral and collective defence arrangements as well as international military co-operation and co-ordination (for an elaborate discussion, see Goldblatt, Held, McGrew and Perraton 1998: chapters 2 and 3). The rising density of technological connections between states now challenges the very idea of national security and national arms procurement. Some of the most advanced weapons-systems in the world today, e.g. fighter aircraft, depend on components which come from many countries.³ There has been a globalisation of military technology linked to a transnationalisation of defence production. And the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction makes all states insecure and problematises the very notions of 'friends' and 'enemies'.

Even in the sphere of defence and arms production and manufacture, the notion of a singular, discrete and delimited political community appears problematic. Indeed, even in this realm, any conception of sovereignty and autonomy which assumes that they denote an indivisible, illimitable, exclusive and perpetual form of public power – embodied within an individual state – is increasingly challenged and eroded.

Democracy and Globalisation: In Sum

At the end of the second millennium, as indicated previously, political communities and civilisations can no longer be characterised simply as 'discrete worlds'; they are enmeshed and entrenched in complex structures of overlapping forces, relations and movements (cf. Fernández-Armesto 1995). Four points can be noted to help characterise the changing relationship between globalisation and democratic nation-states.

First, the locus of effective political power can no longer be assumed to be national governments – effective power is shared, bartered and struggled over by diverse forces and agencies at national, regional and international levels. Second, the idea of a political community of fate – of a self-determining collectivity – can no longer meaningfully be located within the boundaries of a single nation-state alone. Some of the most fundamental forces and processes which determine the nature of life-chances within and

across political communities are now beyond the reach of nation-states. The system of national political communities persists of course; but it is articulated and re-articulated today with complex economic, organisational, administrative, legal and cultural processes and structures which limit and check its efficacy. If these processes and structures are not acknowledged and brought into the political process themselves, they will tend to bypass or circumvent the democratic state system.

Third, it is not part of my argument that national sovereignty today, even in regions with intensive overlapping and divided political and authority structures, has been wholly subverted – not at all. But it is part of my argument that there are significant areas and regions marked by criss-crossing loyalties, conflicting interpretations of rights and duties, interconnected legal and authority structures etc., which displace notions of sovereignty as an inimitable, indivisible and exclusive form of public power. The operations of states in increasingly complex regional and global systems both affects their autonomy (by changing the balance between the costs and benefits of policies) and their sovereignty (by altering the balance between national, regional and international legal frameworks and administrative practices). While massive concentrations of power remain features of many states, these are frequently embedded in, and articulated with, fractured domains of political authority. Against this background, it is not fanciful to imagine, as Bull once observed, the development of an international system which is a modern and secular counterpart to the kind of political organisation found in Christian Europe in the Middle Ages, the essential characteristic of which was a system of overlapping authority and multiple loyalties (1977: 254-5).

Fourth, the late twentieth century is marked by a significant series of new types of ‘boundary problem’. If it is accepted that we live in a world of overlapping communities of fate, where the trajectories of each and every country are more tightly entwined than ever before, then new types of boundary problem follow. In the past, of course, nation-states principally resolved their differences over boundary matters by pursuing reasons of state backed by coercive means. But this power logic is singularly inadequate and inappropriate to resolve the many complex issues, from economic regulation to resource depletion and environmental degradation, which engender an intermeshing of ‘national fortunes’. In Zimbabwe, it is said, many villagers used to believe that weather patterns were due to ‘acts of God’ – and, accordingly, climate shifts had to be accepted; today, the same

people believe that their weather is affected by Western energy policy, patterns of pollution as well as some local practices and, of course, some bad luck. In a world where powerful states make decisions not just for their peoples but for others as well, and where transnational actors and forces cut across the boundaries of national communities in diverse ways, the questions of who should be accountable to whom, and on what grounds, do not easily resolve themselves. Overlapping spheres of influence, interference and interest create fundamental problems at the centre of democratic thought, problems which ultimately concern the very basis of democratic authority.

Part III: Rethinking Democracy in the Context of Globalisation

In the liberal democracies, consent to government and legitimacy for governmental action are dependent upon electoral politics and the ballot box. Yet, the notion that consent legitimates government, and that the ballot box is the appropriate mechanism whereby the citizen body as a whole periodically confers authority on government to enact the law and regulate economic and social life, become problematic as soon as the nature of a 'relevant community' is contested. What is the proper constituency, and proper realm of jurisdiction, for developing and implementing policy with respect to health issues such as AIDS or BSE (Bovine Spongiform Encephalopathy), the use of nuclear energy, the management of nuclear waste, the harvesting of rain forests, the use of non-renewable resources, the instability of global financial markets, the reduction of the risks of chemical and nuclear warfare? National boundaries have demarcated traditionally the basis on which individuals are included and excluded from participation in decisions affecting their lives; but if many socioeconomic processes, and the outcomes of decisions about them, stretch beyond national frontiers, then the implications of this are serious, not only for the categories of consent and legitimacy but for all the key ideas of democracy. At issue is the nature of a constituency (how should the proper boundaries of a constituency be drawn?), the meaning of representation (who should represent whom and on what basis?), and the proper form and scope of political participation (who should participate and in what way?). As fundamental processes of governance escape the categories of the nation-state, the traditional

national resolutions of the key questions of democratic theory and practice are open to doubt.

Against this background, the nature and prospects of the democratic polity need re-examination. The idea of a democratic order can no longer be simply defended as an idea suitable to a particular closed political community or nation-state. We are compelled to recognise that we live in a complex interconnected world where the extensity, intensity and impact of issues (economic, political or environmental) raise questions about where those issues are most appropriately addressed. Deliberative and decision-making centres beyond national territories are appropriately situated when those significantly affected by a public matter constitute a cross-border or transnational grouping, when 'lower' levels of decision-making cannot manage and discharge satisfactorily transnational or international policy questions, and when the principle of democratic legitimacy can only be properly redeemed in a transnational context (see Held 1995: chapter 10). If the most powerful geopolitical interests are not to settle many pressing matters simply in terms of their objectives and by virtue of their power, then new institutions and mechanisms of accountability need to be established.

It would be easy to be pessimistic about the future of democracy. There are plenty of reasons for pessimism; they include the fact that the essential political units of the world are still based on nation-states while some of the most powerful socio-political forces of the world escape the boundaries of these units. In reaction to this, in part, new forms of fundamentalism have arisen along with new forms of tribalism – all asserting the a priori superiority of a particular religious, or cultural, or political identity over all others, and all asserting their sectional aims and interests. In addition, the reform of the UN that is currently contemplated by the most powerful countries is focused on efforts to include other powerful countries, above all, Germany and Japan. This would consolidate the power of certain geopolitical interests, but at the expense of many other countries which have some of the fastest rates of economic growth and some of the largest populations. I believe this position to be unsustainable in the long run.

But there are other forces at work which create the basis for a more optimistic reading of democratic prospects. An historical comparison might help to provide a context for this. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, Europe was marked by civil conflict, religious strife and fragmented authority; the idea of a secular state, separate from

ruler and ruled, and separate from the church, seemed an unlikely prospect. Parts of Europe were tearing themselves to pieces and, yet, within 150-200 years, a new concept of politics became entrenched, based around a new concept of the state. Today, we live at another fundamental point of transition, but now to a more transnational, global world. There are forces and pressures which are engendering a reshaping of political cultures, institutions and structures. First, one must obviously note the emergence, however hesitatingly, of regional and global institutions in the twentieth century. The UN is, of course, weak in many respects, but it is a relatively recent creation and it is an innovative structure which can be built upon. It is a normative resource which provides – for all its difficulties – an enduring example of how nations might (and sometimes do) cooperate better to resolve, and resolve fairly, common problems. In addition, the development of a powerful regional body such as the European Union is a remarkable state of affairs. Just over fifty years ago Europe was at the point of self-destruction. Since that moment Europe has created new mechanisms of collaboration, human rights enforcement, and new political institutions in order not only to hold member states to account across a broad range of issues, but to pool aspects of their sovereignty. Furthermore, there are, of course, new regional and global transnational actors contesting the terms of globalisation – not just corporations but new social movements such as the environmental movement, the women's movement and so on. These are the 'new' voices of an emergent 'transnational civil society', heard, for instance, at the Rio Conference on the Environment, the Cairo Conference on Population Control and the Beijing Conference on Women. In short, there are tendencies at work seeking to create new forms of public life and new ways of debating regional and global issues. These are, of course, all in early stages of development, and there are *no* guarantees that the balance of political contest will allow them to develop. But they point in the direction of establishing new modes of holding transnational power systems to account – that is, they help open up the possibility of what I call 'cosmopolitan democracy'.

If this possibility is to be consolidated, each citizen of a state must learn to become a cosmopolitan citizen – a person capable of mediating between national traditions, communities and alternative forms of life. Citizenship in a democratic polity of the future must increasingly involve a mediating role: a role which encompasses dialogue with the traditions and discourses of others with the aim of expanding the horizons of one's own framework of meaning and prejudice, and increas-

ing the scope of mutual understanding. Political agents who can reason from the point of view of others are likely to be better equipped to resolve, and resolve fairly, the new and challenging transboundary issues that create overlapping communities of fate. Moreover, if many contemporary forms of power are to become accountable and if many of the complex issues that affect us all – locally, nationally, regionally and globally – are to be democratically regulated, people must have access to, and membership in, diverse political communities. Put differently, democracy for the new millennium should describe a world where citizens enjoy multiple citizenships. They should be citizens of their own communities, of the wider regions in which they live, and of a cosmopolitan, transnational community.

Against this background, democracy must be thought of as a ‘double-sided process’ (Held 1996). By a double-sided process I mean not just the deepening of democracy within a national community, but also the extension of democratic processes across territorial borders. Democracy for the new millennium must involve cosmopolitan citizens able to gain access to, and mediate between, and render accountable, the social, economic and political processes and flows which cut across and transform their traditional community boundaries. The notion of cosmopolitan democracy recognises our complex, interconnected world. It recognises, of course, certain problems and policies as appropriate for local governments and national states; but it also recognises others as appropriate for specific regions, and still others – such as the environment, global security concerns, world health questions and economic regulation – that need new institutions to address them. Such political arrangements are not only a necessity but also a possibility in the light of the changing organisation of regional and global processes, evolving political decision-making centres such as the European Union, and growing political demands for new forms of political deliberation, conflict resolution and decision-making.

NOTES

1. This is a revised and abridged version of 'The Transformation of Political Community', first prepared for publication in Ian Shapiro (ed.), *Democracy's Edges*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, forthcoming.
2. The conception of globalisation along with many of the examples in this section are drawn from this joint volume. I should like to acknowledge my debt to my co-authors with whom I have collaborated over the last four years on these issues.
3. I am indebted to Anthony McGrew for this point.

REFERENCES

- Beetham, D. 1998. 'Human Rights as a Model for Cosmopolitan Democracy', in D. Archibugi, D. Held and M. Köhler (eds), *Re-Imagining Political Community: Studies in Cosmopolitan Democracy*. Cambridge: Polity Press, forthcoming.
- Bobbio, N. 1989. *Democracy and Dictatorship*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Bull, H. 1977. *The Anarchical Society*. London: Macmillan.
- Capotorti, F. 1983. 'Human Rights: the Hard Road towards Universality', in R. St J. Macdonald and D.M. Johnson (eds), *The Structure and Process of International Law*. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff.
- Cassese, A. 1986. *International Law in a Divided World*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.
- Connolly, W. 1991. 'Democracy and Territoriality', *Millennium*, 20:3.
- Crawford, J. 1994. 'Democracy in International Law', Inaugural lecture. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Dahl, R.A. 1989. *Democracy and Its Critics*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Evans, T. 1997. 'Democratization and Human Rights', in A. McGrew (ed.), *The Transformation of Democracy?* Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Fernández-Armesto, F. 1995. *Millennium*. London: Bantam.
- Giddens, A. 1990. *The Consequences of Modernity*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Goldblatt, D., Held, D., McGrew, A.G. & Perraton, J. 1997. 'Economic Globalization and the Nation-state: Shifting Balances of Power', *Soundings*, forthcoming.
- . 1998. *The Global Transformation: Concepts, Arguments and Evidence*. Cambridge: Polity Press, forthcoming.
- Hayek, F.A. 1960. *The Constitution of Liberty*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.

- Held, D. 1995. *Democracy and the Global Order: From the Modern State to Cosmopolitan Governance*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- . 1996. *Models of Democracy*. 2nd edition. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Hirst, P. and Thompson, G. 1996. *Globalisation in Question*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Keohane, R. 1995. 'Hobbes's Dilemma and Institutional Change in World Politics: Sovereignty in International Society', in H.H. Holm & G. Sorensen (eds), *Whose World Order?* Boulder, Col.: Westview Press.
- McGrew, A.G. (ed.) 1997. *The Transformation of Democracy?* Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Mann, M. 1986. *The Sources of Social Power*, Vol. 1. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Ohmae, K. 1990. *The Borderless World*. London: Collins.
- Paine, T. 1987. *The Thomas Paine Reader*. Harmondsworth: Penguin.
- Perraton, J., Goldblatt, D., Held, D. & McGrew, A. 1997. 'The Globalisation of Economic Activity', *New Political Economy*, 2:2.
- Reich, R. 1991. *The Work of Nations*. New York: Simon & Schuster.
- Sabine, G.H. 1963. *A History of Political Theory*. London: Harrap.
- Sandel, M. 1996. *Democracy's Discontent*. Cambridge Mass.: Harvard University Press.
- Walker, R.B.J. 1988. *One World, Many Worlds*. Boulder, Col.: Lynne Rienner.